



RPI Outdoor Programs and Rensselaer Outing Club

Ice Climbing Policies

Introduction:

Ice Climbing has the potential to be a dangerous activity. Due to this inherent danger, the conduct of this activity's leaders and participants must fall under the accepted scope of practice for Ice Climbing at RPI.

This document intends to standardize all Ice Climbing trips and will outline the guidelines and standards for which leaders are permitted to operate. These guidelines and standards meet or exceed industry standards and best practices commonly accepted by professional practitioners throughout the greater outdoor education and recreation industry.

Ice Climbing trip leaders are approved using the standards outlined in the document, including guidelines of conduct and the organization's accepted scope of practice. Components of this document incorporate leading industry practices, years of combined experience, and the organization's culture/legacy in high consideration.

This document is organized by Program Overview and Guiding Principles, Trip Leader Qualifications, Trips Classifications, Approved Gear List, and Proper Trip Planning and Documentation.

Program Overview and Guiding Principles:

Ice Climbing is the action in which a climber uses specialized equipment to ascend an inclined ice formation. The techniques used to accomplish this task vary widely. This variability demonstrates the crucial need to define acceptable levels of risk and available opportunities for practitioners under RPI Outdoor Programs. The following key considerations should be present in Ice Climbing programs conducted by OP and ROC.

Role of the Leaders:

- When facilitating an Ice Climbing trip, leadership needs to be established to monitor unwarranted risks to the participants, leaders, equipment, and institution.
 - Leadership is defined as:
 - Assistant Ice Climbing Leader (i.e., Assistant Leader)
 - Ice Climbing Trip Leader (i.e., Trip Leader)
- Leaders of these trips need to undergo the proper leadership development and training and possess ample knowledge for the experience they are providing.
- Trip leadership must adhere to the policies and standards that provide the framework for the experience; this includes working within the accepted scope of practice.
- Trip Leaders will act professionally while considering the needs of the participant.

Risk Management:

- Trip Leaders will prioritize risk management before, during, and following a trip.
- Numerous factors contribute to the overall safety of all who are involved in the experience.
 - Location, weather, wildlife, terrain, equipment, physical ability, health concerns, distractions, etc., all contribute to potential risks on a program.
- At no point can Trip Leaders ensure all risk factors are eliminated. However, a leader must communicate the inherent risks involved with the activity to inform participants of potential risks.
- It is a major responsibility of an Ice Climbing Trip Leader to anticipate realistic risk factors and prevent exposure to the best of their ability.

Etiquette:

- Ice Climbing can occur in wild and remote locations that are susceptible to negative effects of misbehaved visitors. This requires proper etiquette for all who engage in Ice Climbing trips through Outdoor Programs.
- Leave No Trace Principles should be followed on every trip.
- Wilderness First Aid should be administered within the scope of the trip leader's abilities.
- Personal goals or trip itineraries should be replaced if another party requiring medical assistance is needed.
- All leaders and participants will abide by Challenge by Choice and Full Value Contract practices.

General Program Policies:

- The sport of Ice Climbing requires a significant amount of physical exertion. Trip leaders and participants should be in good physical health to meet the challenging demands of the ice climbing environment
- Trip leaders must abide by the guiding principles mentioned above.
- Trips will not go out without having at least one Trip Leader and one Assistant Leader.
- Trips will not depart the campus (or trailhead in the case of previous arrival) in the event of a serious inclement weather threat (e.g., extreme low temperature, high wind chill/speeds, travel restrictions, avalanche warnings, ice fall, etc.).
- All trips will follow local and state laws and regulations regarding the intended activity.
- Ice Climbing Trips will follow the Trip Plan and GRO Submission Policy.
- Maximum participant-to-leader ratio is 6:2 on an Ice Climbing Trip.
- Helmets must be worn whenever technical gear is being used or within the vicinity of climbers. (crampons, ice axes, ropes, ice climbing tools, etc.)
- Lead climbing is not permitted on any Ice Climbing Trip provided by OP or ROC.
- Unless they are belaying or climbing, all participants should remain away from the base of the cliff.
- A fall arrest system (tether, hard-point connection, belay, etc.) must be used for any persons within 10 feet of the cliff's edge

Trip Leader Qualifications:

The following requirements are for aspiring Trip Leaders before they are presumed qualified to lead Ice Climbing Trips for Outdoor Programs or Rensselaer Outing Club as either an Assistant Ice Climbing Trip Leader or an Ice Climbing Trip Leader.

Assistant Leader:

- Has a current WFA and CPR certification.
- Has completed the RPI OP & ROC Rock Climbing Leadership Course
- Has participated in at least one Ice Climbing Trip through OP or ROC.
- Can communicate effectively under stress or exposure to harsh environments.
- Ability to read common snow and ice features. Must be able to anticipate dangers associated with snow, slab/vertical/overhanging ice, and snowpack.
- Knowledge of Winter specific technical skills

- o Technical steep terrain traveling techniques.
 - Use of crampons
 - How to properly identify, size, and fit crampons
 - Familiar with crampon techniques that are appropriate for the terrain
 - Proper use and technique of ice climbing tools
- Has the ability to climb WI 3
- Has the ability to anticipate, identify, and treat cold weather injuries and medical conditions related to cold exposure.
- An understanding of Outdoor Programs and Rensselaer Outing Club General and Ice Climbing Policies.

Trip Leader:

Ice Climbing Trip Leaders will have all the qualifications of an Assistant Leader as well as...

- Has been an Assistant Leader on at least two OP or ROC Ice Climbing Trips.
 - o One of these two assistant lead trips needs to be at the selected location of the proposed trip. (or Advanced 'scouting' trip)
- Has passed the RPI OP and ROC Rock Climbing Leadership Course practical examination and written test. (or equivalent 3rd party certification)
- Has received Trip Leader approval from Outdoor Programs professional staff and ROC ECOMM

Trip Classifications:

Introductory:

Introductory Ice Climbing trips are designed to introduce participants to the sport of ice climbing without minimum need of previous experience. Trips at this level should be centered around the introduction, instruction, and basic skill development associated with the sport of Ice Climbing. Students should never have to apply technical skills in critical scenarios on an Introductory level trip (e.g., rappelling, climbing out of a location, technical approaches, etc.). Considerations are made with ease of travel and proximity to resources for rescue/aid in a scenario where outside support is required (i.e., approach is ≤ 1 mile). Exposure to risks associated with avalanches, damaging temperatures/wind, unprotected exposure to heights, steep terrain, low visibility, thin ice, and other unforeseen risks should be intentionally avoided on Introductory level trips.

Intermediate:

Trips at the Intermediate level require participants to possess previous ice climbing experience and instruction to participate. The aim of Intermediate level trips is for the further development of ice climbing abilities and general enjoyment. Trips at this level will have an emphasis on skill-building and less emphasis on instruction. A range of climbing difficulties (WI 2 – WI 4) is appropriate for an Intermediate trip. Approaches on an Intermediate Ice Climbing trip can be longer in distance but should not include any use of technical equipment to access the climbing site (i.e., rappelling, climbing, fixed lines, etc.)

Advanced:

An Advanced Ice Climbing Trip classification is reserved for Ice Climbing at a higher difficulty than an Intermediate trip (e.g., WI 4 – WI 5). For an Advanced Ice Climbing trip, the participant-to-leader ratio is reduced to 4:2. A participant on an Advanced Ice Climbing Trip should have significant ice climbing experience. Technical approaches may be allowed. This includes the use of rappelling in or climbing out to access the climbing location. Advanced Ice Climbing trips require a pre-trip meeting with Outdoor Programs professional staff and proposed Trip Leaders and Assistant Trip leaders before the trip may depart campus. The Advanced level ice climbing rating may be used for scouting a new Introductory/Intermediate trip location.

Approved Gear Lists:

For Participants:

- Ice Climbing Tools
- Ice Climbing Crampons
- Mountaineering Boots
- Climbing Harness
- Climbing Helmet
- Belay Device
- Proper Ice Climbing Clothing: (warm, waterproof, wicking, layered, and packable)
 - o Base Layers
 - o Warm Wool Socks (2x pair)
 - o Mid Layers
 - o Belay Jacket (Large Puffy or Parka for Warmth between climbs)
 - o Outer Shell Jacket
 - o Cold-Weather Pants (NO BAGGY OR LOOSE FITTING PANTS *they will get damaged!) (i.e. Softshell or Alpine Pants)
 - o Wool or Fleece Hat (ideally that can fit under a helmet)

- o Winter Gloves (bring at least 2x pair; a climbing/belaying pair & a warmer backup pair)
- o Gaiters (optional, but nice to have)
- o Sunglasses/Goggles
- Backpack (20L – 40L)
- Food/Water
- Handwarmers
- Insulative pad

For Leaders:

- Climbing Ropes
- Static Ropes
- Repair Kit
- First Aid Kit
- Emergency Mylar Blanket
- A Copy of the Updated Trip Sheet
- Copy of Permits/Waivers (if needed)
- Necessary Climbing Hardware (Carabiners, Quickdraws, Ice Screws, etc.)
- Group Comfort Items (extra handwarmers, Thermos of Coffee/Coco, Group Snack, etc.)

Proper Trip Planning and Documentation:

Pre-Trip Preparations:

Before leaving campus, all trips must submit proper trip documentation under the guidelines and protocols below. It is important to have these documents in place for the protection of the participants, leaders, and the organization. Doing so ensures compliance with programmatic policies and procedures.

Outdoor Trip Plan:

A completed Outdoor Trip Plan (OTP) must be submitted to the shared Outdoor Programs' Trip Plan folder a week before the expected departure date. Notification of trip plan submission must be communicated to the Assistant Director of Outdoor Programs. In the event of trip/itinerary changes (i.e., cancellations, additions, etc.) an updated OTP must be on file before the trip departs. By not doing so, the leaders of the trip will be asked to meet with Outdoor Programs staff, members of ECOMM, and the chair of said activity for review and course of action moving forward.

Permits:

It is unlawful for individuals to access certain lands, parks, preserves, or mountains without the possession of a granted permit. Federal, state, or local

agencies may require permits to access or recreate on land under their jurisdiction. There is a chance that permission is required from multiple levels of these agencies, which could complicate the permitting process. It is the responsibility of the individuals who facilitate Ice Climbing programs to ensure they are permitted to use the land in the intended way.

Waivers:

Every individual involved in an OP or ROC program needs to have an RPI Outdoor Programs Assumption of Risk/Informed Consent Release on file before the start of the program. These waivers allow the participant to make an informed decision about whether they want to participate in the program. Waivers highlight the inherent risks related to the activity and outline anticipated conduct and expectations of both trip leaders and participants.

Fees:

If fees are to be collected for any purpose, participants will need to fill out a Charge/Payment/Adjustment sheet and submit it to OP.